ROCKY ROAD AHEAD FOR THE NEW CM

D.K. SHIVAKUMAR BEGINS HIS TENURE UNDER INTENSE PRESSURE TO DELIVER QUICKLY, MANAGE INTERNAL RIVALS AND KEEP THE CONGRESS MACHINE ELECTION-READY FOR THE 2028 POLLS

By AJAY SUKUMARAN



AFTER A WAIT OF THREE YEARS, D.K. SHIVAKUMAR is finally set to become the chief minister of Karnataka, the summit of a political career that began, improbably, in defeat. In 1985, while just 23, DKS lost his first assembly contest in Sathanur to Janata Dal strongman H.D. Deve Gowda, the former prime minister. He has not lost an assembly election since. Four decades and eight consecutive MLA terms later, the long climb has ended at the top job.

The denouement came on May 28, when chief minister Siddaramaiah, after two suspenseful days, hosted a breakfast for cabinet colleagues and then drove to Raj Bhavan in Bengaluru to hand in his resignation. It marked the end of the run for a leader who, just this January, had become the state's longest-serving chief minister.

Yet the prospect of a mid-term change had loomed over the 77-year-old Siddaramaiah from the moment he returned to power in May 2023. An unwritten "pact" to hand the baton to Shivakumar midway was endlessly speculated upon, though the party

THE CHALLENGES BEFORE DKS

- Sidda has stepped down, but "active presence" may make him a disruptor
- Social and Educational Survey 2025 lands at a perilous moment. Findings may unsettle Vokkaliga, Lingayat dominance
- Congress now needs a new state party chief who will not disturb caste balance, factional peace or Sidda loyalists
- DKS has barely two years to prove that he can run the state effectively and govern well
- Bengaluru civic polls, gram panchayat elections will be first test for new CM